Grounded in Place: Teaching Research Through Local Engagement

CCCC Fall Virtual Institute 2025

Wren Bouwman

IOWA STATE UNIVERSITY

How I Got Here

5 years of teaching intermediate composition courses

Choosing Generic Research Topics

Difficulty Applying "Reasoning"

Increasing Use of Generative A.I.

What I Did

Original Unit:

- 1750+ Word Synthesis Essay
- 5+ Sources
- 1 Required Image

- Required Interview or Observation
- Application of Community Capital Framework

What I Did

Three new lecture points and learning activities:

- Designing Interview Questions
- Community Capitals Framework
- Interview/Observation Notes

Week	Tasks
1: Introducing the Assignment	• Topic Proposal • Potential Sources
2: Finding Evidence	• Interview Questions • CCF Worksheet
3: Crafting an Argument	• CER Worksheet • Sample Paragraphs
4: Conducting Local Research	• Interview/Observation
5: Editing and Peer Review	• Peer Review • Final Draft

Conducting Interview Lesson

Learning Objectives	Deliverables	Prerequisite Knowledge
1. Evaluate how different stakeholders frame the same topic and recognize whose voices may be missing. 2. Develop interview and observation questions that elicit rich, open-ended responses.	1. Source Search Assignment 2. Notes or draft interview email *(optional, for feedback)*	Students should… ● Have identified a research topic ● Understand what makes a source reliable ● Begun searching for potential sources

Community Capitals Framework Lesson

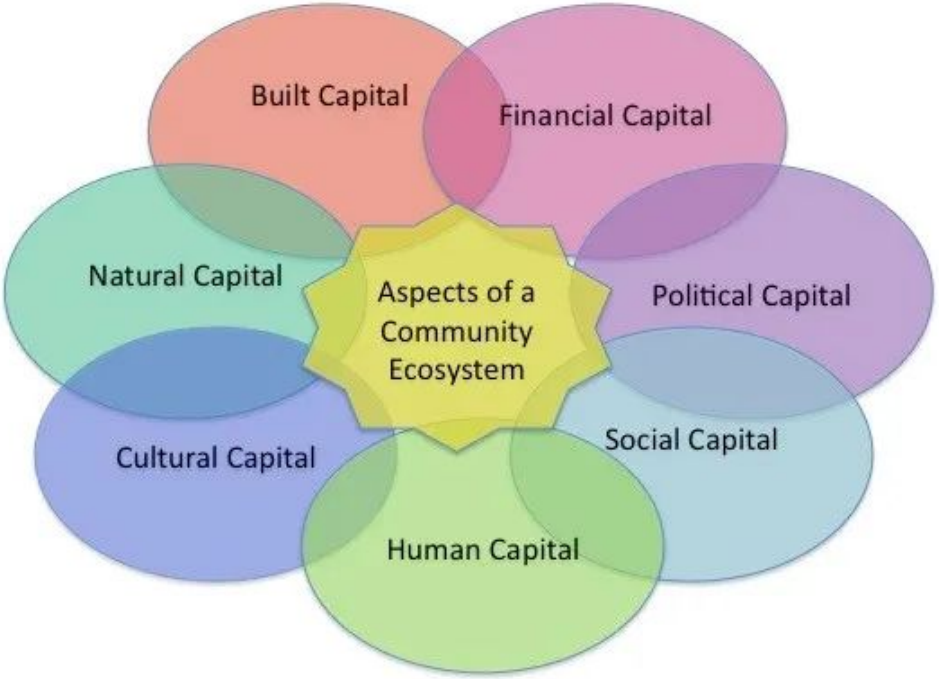
Learning Objectives	Deliverables	Prerequisite Knowledge
1. Identify and define the seven Community Capitals 2. Analyze how these capitals interact within a specific context. 3. Connect the CCF to their ongoing research project or topic, identifying “spiraling up” and “spiraling down” patterns.	1. Completed CCF Worksheet	Students should… ● Have selected a research topic related to a local or social issue. ● Understand basic research methods, including how to identify credible sources and take analytical notes.

Conducting Interviews

Optional: Submit a draft of your email requesting an interview for feedback

1. Identify Focus of Interview
2. Identify What you Want to Know
3. Ask Open-Ended Questions
    a. descriptive (“What’s happening?”)
    b. interpretive (“Why is it happening?”)
    c. reflective (“How do you think it could change?”)

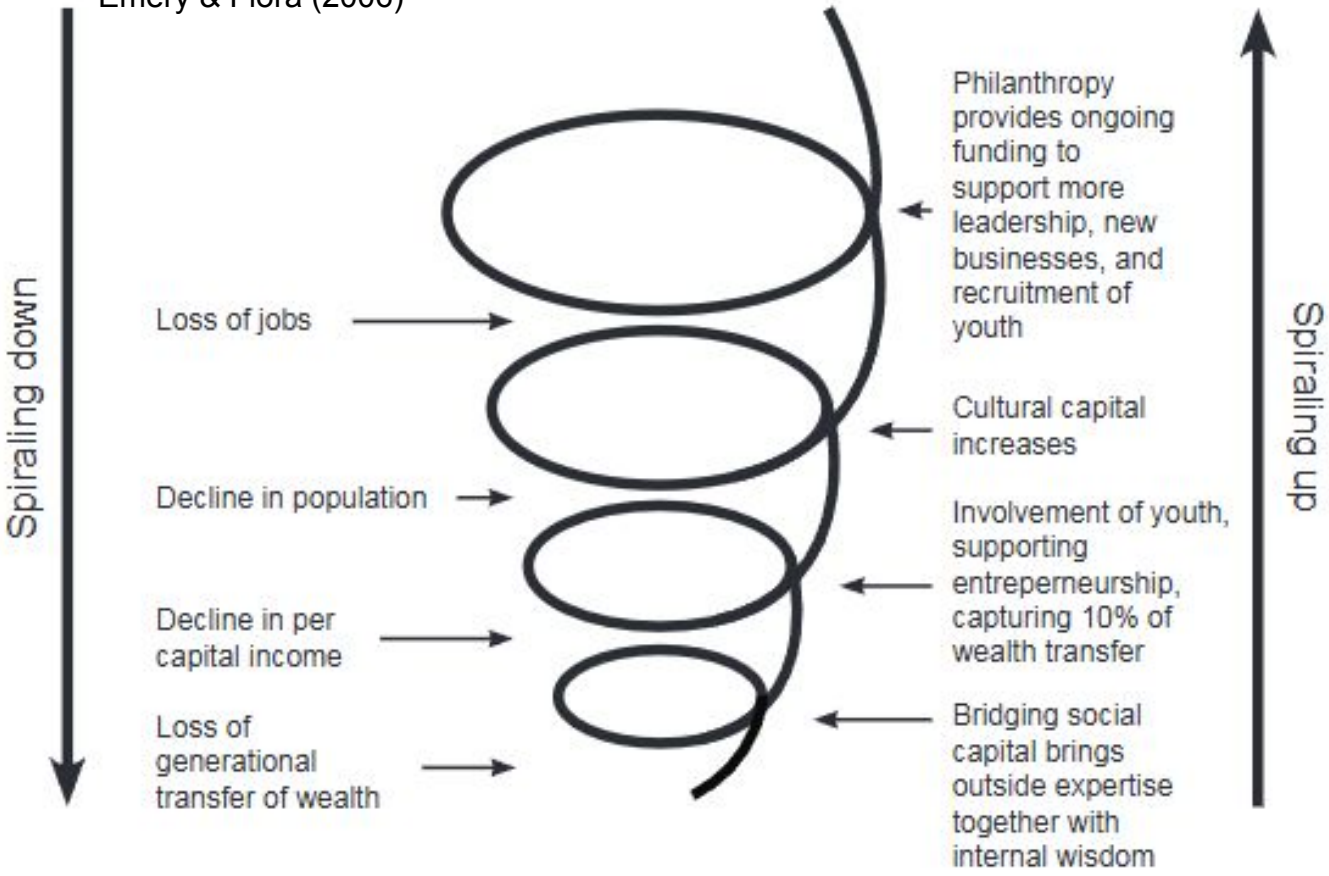
Community Capitals Framework



Source: Community Capitals Framework & Sustainable Communities,
Cornelia Butler Flora, Rural Studies Research Seminar, July 4, 2006, University of Guelph

- Group work with examples of each capital
- Guided Group Reading
- Individual Work

Emery & Flora (2006)



Reading Roles:

- Cartographer
- Evaluator
- Connector

What I'd do differently

- Incorporate CCF earlier and continue it longer
  - Rhetorical Analysis with CCF
  - Multimodal Design aimed at Spiraling Up
- Teach Spiraling Up/Down without reading
- Interactive/scaffolded activities for interview questions

How it went

Choosing Generic Research Topics

Difficulty Applying "Reasoning"

Increasing Use of Generative A.I.

Students chose personal topics

Students referenced capitals

Students had shared language

Continued Collaboration

Wren Bouwman
Ph.D. Candidate

bouwman.wren@gmail.com
bouwman@iastate.edu

At this link, you can find:

- This presentation
- Lesson Plans
- Slide decks
- Student Samples (coming soon)

thewrenegade.github.io/portfolio/cccc-fvi / bit.ly/4ogaf2g